THE ROAD TO SUCCESS

Gillen's tips for potential comic writers

BE UNDERSTANDING

"You write a script quite quickly, but the artist is drawing it for months. I try to write a script a week, but I've done more, I can do more. That leaves a lot of time for you to think about it, but an artist is going to be drawing that script for the rest of the month. At the very, very, very least, there's a 1:4 ratio of time."

ACCEPT YOU MUST IMPROVE

"If you're good enough, people will work with you. I had a friend pitching comics at various publishers. I wasn't doing that, because I wasn't good enough. Why would I want my comics published in a larger market now? I'm just not there yet."

LEARN BY DOING

"If you sit down and write scripts, you will not learn anything until someone draws them. You can write 100 pages of script, you'll learn more when you see one page drawn. You'll see every stupid mistake you're doing. Comic scripts are a blueprint for an art form."

HAVE SELF-RESPECT

"There's lots of ways to blow it, but being good will buy you a chance. I'm not saying I'm the best comic-book writer in any way ever; I've just had nothing published where I'm embarrassed to have my name on it. There are anthologies where I could've done better, but I'm not kicking myself over it, and that's important."

INCONSISTENCY IS PART OF THE BUSINESS

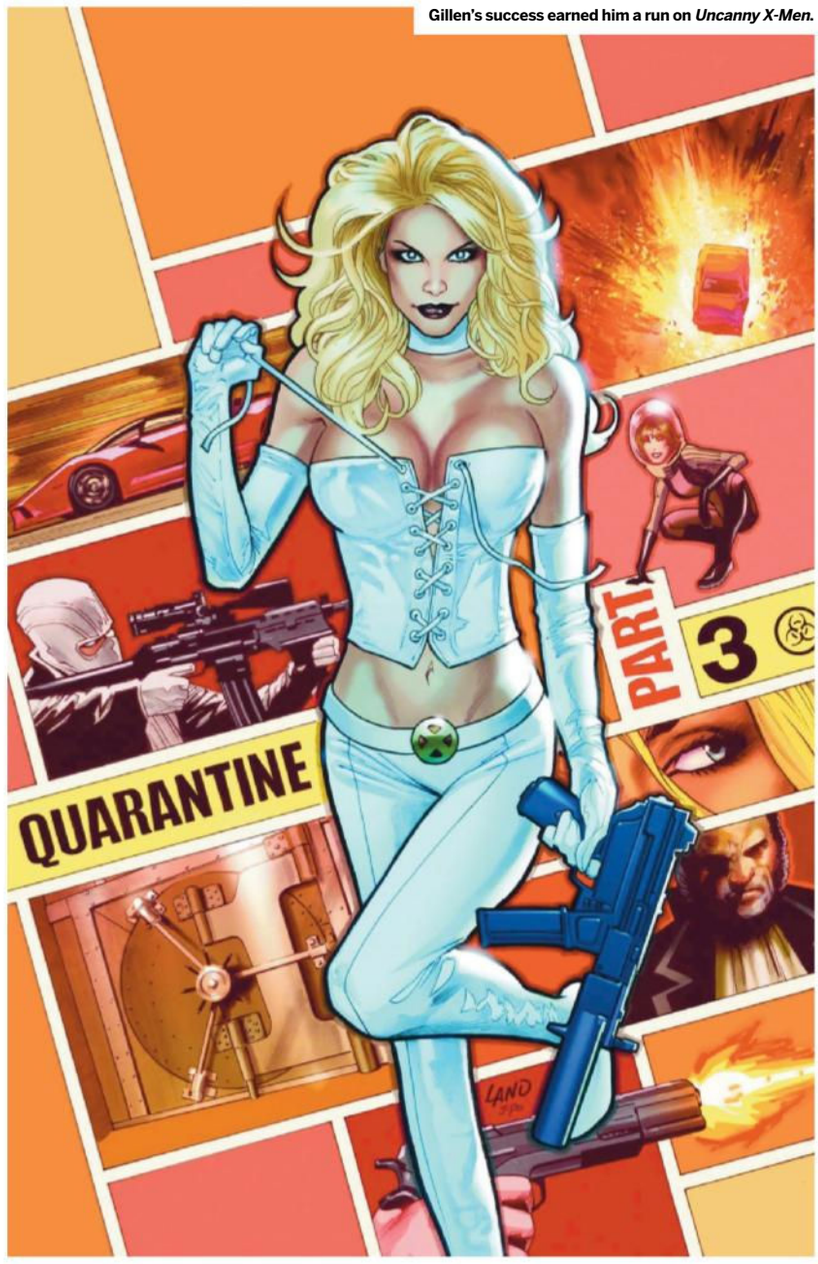
"You're just going to have to deal with a lot of artists flaking. My first work was on something called *Hits*, which had stories about the different definitions of the word 'hit'. I wrote ten scripts, and five of them got drawn. Five of the artists I worked with flaked. That's a pretty good ratio."

kind of an 'in' at Image there." Gillen was pitching the book at Oni Press at the time with one page, a script and a seven-page pitch document. Image approached them, however, asking that the book be sent in their direction. "That was easy. Everything else about *Phonogram* was hard, but the pitching process… we did some pages, we took it to them, they liked it, and we did a comic."

Economically, *Phonogram* ran into the hurdles that can affect any creator-owned independent comic book. Despite being well-received, it didn't reach the same numbers as other, more mainstream-friendly titles at Image, due in part to its subject of Britpop fantasy. The direct market, where retailers have to pay for books up front without being able to return them, naturally makes any purchase a gamble for comic-book stores. *Phonogram* was selling, but not enough to fund it as a monthly operation.

"The problem with Image is it's a back-end deal," Gillen explains. "They don't, as a matter of course, do up-front payments… you get your money three months later based upon how many copies were ordered. So you don't get any money, even if it sells well, until after the comic comes out. In that case, you've got an artist who is basically drawing for free. Writers generally don't get the money, in that case."

The maths turned out to be difficult for the creators. "Let's say the first 3,000 copies you sell go to Image, which is for the printing. You pay back the printing, you pay back the fee for running the book, that kind of stuff. And anything over those first 3,000 copies is yours. Let's say you get a dollar an issue for 3,001 copies; you get one dollar. 4,000 copies, you get $1,000. You basically get a higher wage if you're selling a few percent more. *Phonogram* sold about 4,000 copies on pre-orders. In other words, reduce that a bit, and you can see very little money coming in from that. If we were selling even slightly more, Jamie would've been okay."



Gillen's success earned him a run on *Uncanny X-Men*.

Gillen and McKelvie learned to accept this as part of the industry, but the book couldn't continue with so little money coming in for the creators. "That's basically what screws you as a creator-owned, back-end book. On the other hand, if you're a hit, you can do really well – *The Walking Dead* is doing incredibly well. We were never going to be *The Walking Dead* with *Phonogram* because it's an awkward bastard and it's very dislikeable, but even if it did slightly better – 6,000 issues a month – that would have been securable. But that's comics. Artists basically starve, and writers spend the entire time working out how on earth they can actually get some more money for the artist."

Here's the key point to remember, though. Despite every struggle Gillen and McKelvie encountered when putting *Phonogram* out there, the experience was tremendously validating to them. "Oh yeah. Would I be doing anything I'm doing now without *Phonogram*? Hell no. *Phonogram* was an incredible artistic experience. Like Jack Kirby says, comics will break your heart. There was something of Rorschach to it; we do not choose to do this thing, we do it because we feel compelled. If I had any sense, I probably wouldn't have been doing it, but if I had any sense, I'd probably have got another job at some point in my life. You are driven by your passion. And a book like *Phonogram*, it is a bit of a weird book. But the fact that people did respond to it… we've done like 13-14,000 of the first trade at least. These aren't small numbers. It did find an audience, just not an audience that can lead to the production of a comic-book in a regular fashion."

Phonogram paid off for Gillen, whose mainstream work is held in high esteem by readers and critics. "There's a very old line in the comic-book industry that applies to almost all creative industries – three qualities. Being good, being personable, and being on time. Any two of those qualities will get you all the work you could ever require anywhere."

Gillen believes that the future of comics buying is heading in two directions, which could be potentially positive for new creators – the digital platforms, where the